Such protests appeared to fall on deaf ears, however, since in November 1921, Curzon had cause yet again to complain of Churchill's behaviour: 'I find it very difficult to conduct foreign affairs at all under the conditions which are constantly created, not infrequently by yourself at Cabinet meetings.'[153] Such problems with Churchill compounded what was already a trying time for Curzon. The foreign secretary's speech to the House of Lords in July, in which he had confessed experiencing a feeling of 'disappointment, almost of despair' at the situation in Persia, certainly had an element of truth to it.[154] Given his self-promotion as an expert on Persia, the failure of the Anglo-Persian Agreement represented both a professional and personal blow.

By the end of 1921, then, Curzon's ego was feeling quite bruised. This may go some way to explaining the foreign secretary's sensitivity towards Churchill's actions that year, as well as the apparent mood of sulkiness towards all things Persia and his stubbornness when it came to Afghanistan. Nevertheless, Curzon rarely accepted fault for anything, but instead complained that 'the responsibility for all the catastrophes that impend in Persia is that of the War Office to begin with, the India Office in the second place, and the Cabinet in the third'. In a letter to his replacement in Tehran, however, Norman put forth a very different account of Curzon's actions in 1921. He reminded his successor how lucky he was:

You have not been called upon to push through an impossible and insane policy, been loaded with the most virulent abuse because you could not do it, and been thwarted at every turn when you tried to save your official chief from the consequences of his own vanity and folly.[155]

The Year of the Treaty

This chapter started with questions surrounding the notion of change in Britain's foreign policy in 1921. Was this year a turning point for Britain? In the year of the treaty, did these numerous documents produced between